Those days are long gone. At a policy level at least, the BJP has fundamentally changed its attitudes to women. From the early 2000s, the BJP and the RSS worked hard to course-correct. They actively reached out to Indian women with a new gender-focused discourse, higher representation and refocused governmental schemes. They did so by focusing on a highly public strategy that was centred on fields that involve physical activity and were hitherto seen as male domains. It is telling that so many leading women athletes—from Paralympics silver medallist Deepa Mehta to Olympics bronze medallist Saina Nehwal to wrestler Babita Phogat—joined the BJP after Modi came to power.

This shift was exemplified by Modi's 2017 speech to women business leaders. 'Today, this country's women are flying combat jets, are going to space, winning medals at the Olympics for the country,' said Modi. 'From panchayats to Parliament, from villages to Silicon Valley, Indian women are shining. And so this imagination that women are only home-bound is a myth.'[136] When speaking to women party leaders in 2018, he focused on the need to change the social norms that differentiate between men and women, specifically in the context of sexual harassment:[137]

We ask fifty questions to daughters. Who is the daughter speaking to, why did she come late, what is she doing, who came? But do we, who ask questions to our daughters, ever question our sons? Where do you go, who are your friends, who do you meet, who do you speak to, why did you come late at night, where did you spend the night, if you are going out, then with whom? We don't even ask our sons. Only when sons keep in mind their values and boundaries, will they keep in mind society's rules.

Not surprisingly, there continue to be contradictions in the party's positions on gender questions. In 2017, for instance, the Congress demanded an apology from the BJP, quoting from a 2014 blog by newly appointed UP Chief Minister Adityanath, in which he had ostensibly written that 'women power … does not require freedom, but protection'.[138] From Unnao MP Sakshi Maharaj asking